



Operation Keystone Eagle

The First Battalion, Ninth Marine Regiment board the troop ship *USS Paul Revere* at Da Nang, headed for Okinawa. Their departure on July 14, 1969, followed a lavish ceremony for the Ninth Marines, who were some of the first troops redeployed as a result of Vietnamization.

The three selfs

Nation building in South Vietnam also required many nonmilitary improvements to the country's infrastructure and institutions. The country needed rural pacification, public services, economic viability, and security for its citizens. However, policing, land reforms, controlling inflation, holding local elections, rooting out Viet Cong, and increasing the rice harvest were not improvements that US military assistance alone could provide. The South Vietnamese summarized their needs as self-defense, self-government, and self-development—known as the three selfs.

Vietnamization assessed

The success of the policy was difficult to measure. South Vietnam provided well for refugees, and succeeded at land redistribution. Roads that had been unsafe were made usable. The rice harvest in 1969 was the best in five years, and tractors replaced water buffalo for plowing. Accomplishments were modest, but genuine.

Success in terms of the war effort was harder to pinpoint. Viet Cong and North Vietnamese activity decreased in many areas of South Vietnam but likely not because of increased ARVN size. The politburo in Hanoi held back, biding its time for further US withdrawals. Meanwhile, low morale and weak leadership continued to plague Saigon's troops. Those tasked with training the ARVN struggled to keep up with the timetable created by Nixon's administration. There was simply not enough time.